resulted in a popular revolt against her, forcing her to flee. Among the first actions that the new interim government took was to lift the ban against the Jamaat. And ever since, anti-Indian forces seem to have gained ground, with many of the student leaders suspected to have links with radical Islamist organisations, including the Jamaat. "There seems to be a shift towards Islamist radicalism," Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty, former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh, confirms. "It is certainly on the rise as is religious intolerance, and that is a cause for worry for India. India is also concerned that the new dispensation will push for closer ties with Pakistan and be inimical to our interests. Pakistan could get a base to stoke trouble in our northeastern states as they did earlier."

INDIAN FOREIGN SECY VIKRAM MISRI'S DEC. 9 VISIT TO DHAKA WAS MEANT TO TAMP DOWN THE RISING ANTI-INDIA RHETORIC AND ENSURE MINORITIES' SAFETY

Experts see clear signs of the new regime's eagerness for close ties with Pakistan. As evidence, they point to the cargo vessel from Karachi that docked at Chittagong port recently, a first since the country's independence in 1971. Visa constraints were also lifted for Pakistanis in certain categories. At the same time, a road illumination project undertaken by the Awami League-ruled Chattogram City Corporation with financial aid from India has been cancelled. On November 19, the Bangladesh Supreme Court also ordered the government to form a committee to review the country's much-debated contract with Adani Power after a petitioner alleged its terms were unfavourable to the country. The 25-year power purchase agreement was signed in 2017 for the company to supply electricity from its 1,600 MW power in plant in Jharkhand. Currently, the Bangladesh Power Development Board owes Adani around $850 million (Rs 7,216 crore).

GREAT POWER GAMES

All these developments have evoked consternation among Indian foreign policy-makers who maintain that India has high stakes in Bangladesh remaining stable, secular and independent. In the past decade and a half of Hasina's tenure, New Delhi was able to craft a durable bilateral relationship that spanned a whole gamut of sectors. India's trade with Bangladesh in this period grew threefold. Exports to Bangladesh rose from $3.34 billion (Rs 28,343 crore) in 2010-11, in the early phase of her last tenure, to $12 billion (Rs 1.02 lakh crore) in 2022-23. Imports from Bangladesh grew at a more modest rate, from $0.45 billion to $2.03 billion. India exports a diverse range of products to Bangladesh, including cotton yarn, petroleum products, oils, spices, vegetables and



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auto components. Bangladesh, in turn, sends us readymade cotton garments, jute, leather footwear and marine products. India has also extended a $7.8 billion (Rs 66,190 crore) line of credit for infrastructure projects in Bangladesh. Right through this current crisis, both sides have wisely refrained from using punitive measures like disrupting trade and business relations just to spite or coerce the other.

India is also concerned that other big powers have been elbowing into what it considers its backyard. In 2016, during Chinese president Xi Jinping's visit to Dhaka, the two nations signed a flurry of agreements that would see Bangladesh receive $26 billion in investments for its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) projects and $14 billion for joint venture projects. Last year, the Chinese foreign ministry estimated that it had released $4.45 billion for 35 projects under the BRI, mainly in the energy and transportation sectors, including the impressive Padma bridge project across the Ganga that would link the southwest of the country to the northern and eastern regions. China is now Bangladesh's largest trading partner, the volume being around $25 billion.

It has also been employing submarine diplomacy, selling Bangladesh two attack submarines at bargain prices in 2016. A year later, it signed a contract to construct a new submarine base on the country's southeastern coast for $1.2 billion, ostensibly to service the vessels they sold. In addition to maintaining these submarines, Chinese personnel would also train the Bangladesh Navy to ply them.

Meanwhile, concerned by China's inroads into Bangladesh